In Sadiya, Assam, the buzz around finding alternative routes to Tibet and even South China was gaining ground. British interest in the region beyond the crest of the Himalayas had been renewed when the Qing government sent military forces under General Zhao Ehrfing to establish a Chinese administration in Tibet in 1910. A year later, another large mixed force under General Bowers moved up the Siang River with the intention of finding the overland route. Once again, the troops were almost immediately embroiled in a running fight with the Abor tribes who fought the British force with all the jungle guile they could bring to bear. Casualties were heavy and the expedition had to turn back.

Despite the military reverses, agreements with various tribal leaders had been reached which would allow the British to expand their administrative reach into the region. However, this time, there was a lot of negative commentary in the press; both the expense and effectiveness of using army units were openly being questioned. The consensus was that small parties with Lakhimpur Battalion (Assam Rifles) escorts would be far more successful in achieving their objectives.